

Why I Felt **HOT IN JAPAN** Even In January

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Emerging trends in wearable electronics, manufacturing lines and automobiles brought to you from NEPCON Japan

I was lucky enough to be there at NEPCON Japan and attend various co-located shows including *Wearable Electronics Expo 2018*. With 2500-plus exhibitors, it was almost impossible to even pass through all exhibitor booths, so I

focused on sectors where a lot of innovations and technologies were being announced. Here are some of the key trends I would like to share with you...

Wearable electronics

This is a very hot sector comprising diverse players including chemicals, materials, components and chips, modules, devices and service providers.

Within wearables, smart glasses are gaining momentum. Multiple players are ready with their solutions. Some have already launched their glasses, while others are about to introduce them this year. The billion dollar question is: Will 2018 be the tipping point for this product category?

Smart glasses are still very expensive, starting from US\$ 1000. While Google and Microsoft are already the champions in this category, and are developing platforms based on which others can provide solutions to their customers, Japanese brands seem to be developing their own glasses along with software stacks for specific customers, thus controlling their go-to-market destiny. They are also open to connect with distributors and system integrators who can use their technology to develop or resell solutions in other nations.

Westunitis demonstrated two different offerings: Infolinker smart glasses with an inbuilt fully-powered computer that can do all data crunching by itself, and PicoLinker 'display only' smart glasses that stream data via Bluetooth from any mobile device.

BLINCAM demonstrated a cute wearable camera that attaches to your spectacles or sunglasses and allows you to take pictures by blinking your eye (in a particular fashion). That means you can experience a great performance without having to disturb your view with your camera or mobile phone, and clap louder too!

Boston Club, a leading Japanese eyewear OEM and ODM, showcased neoplug np-001, which is essentially a smart attachment and detachment slide system for you to put your wearable on your glasses. According

